University of Rochester
Warner Graduate School of Education

EDU 442 Race, Class, Gender, and Disability in American Education

Spring 2026 • Mondays 4:50 – 7:30
LeChase 161

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Office hours as requested. It usually works to meet before or after class.
Class Google Drive:
https://drive.google.com/drive/u/0/folders/1c-oBFLoAaaCAXMhm93e3SwkZ7c0vg094

"To teach in a manner that respects and cares for the souls of our students is essential if we are to provide the necessary conditions where learning can most deeply and intimately begin." –bell hooks, *Teaching to Transgress*

Course Description and Objectives

The purpose of this course is to explore how and in what ways schools produce social inequalities based on socially constructed conceptions of identity (e.g., race, class, gender, gender identity, ethnicity, sexual orientation, (dis)ability, language). Students will critically analyze relevant literature, and their own experiences as raced, classed, gendered, (dis)abled, etc. individuals to develop an understanding of how educational institutions serve as agents of the transmission of social injustice and how schools might work for justice and equity. Students will understand race, class, gender, (dis)ability and other identity markers as intersected and mutually constituted, not as isolated variables. This course will also examine how human diversity frames and is framed by our lives, and how the transformation of social and educational practices might re-shape lives.

This course was designed to help students develop a sense of social responsibility and a desire to effect justice related change in their own lives, their teaching/counseling practice, and in the wider society. Our goal is for students to understand that we have a collective responsibility to improve society, and that, in their roles as *cultural workers,* teachers, school leaders, and counselors are uniquely placed to either reproduce or rupture historical patterns and practices of exclusion, disrespect, and marginalization of students in schools. Through readings, graded assignments, class discussions, and other activities, students will develop a critical understanding (consciousness) of how race, class, gender, (dis)ability, and other markers of social difference reveal the privileging of some and the marginalization of others within K-12 schools. Furthermore, by considering their potential to act as agents of change, students will devise and share tentative yet tangible strategies for liberatory educational practices. These strategies will provide a basis for students continued and ongoing explorations of identity, difference, and social justice in American schooling.

While K-12 schools in the United States have traditionally functioned as sites of social reproduction, bringing new generations face to face with the inequities and injustices of society

at large, these very spaces have also demonstrated their capacity to foster individual and collective acts of resistance against social, cultural, historical, political, and ideological domination and oppression. In this course, we will explore the reproductive and transformative potentials of American schooling by investigating the following two questions:

1) *How do social constructions of identity and difference throughout U.S. society at large inform the organization of and participatory patterns within K-12 educational institutions, and*
2) *How can liberatory educators and other co-conspirators work toward providing transformative and liberating educational experiences for all children and youth?*

To underscore the relevance of the issues that surface in this course, students will be asked to wed broader analyses of the social contexts of education with personal reflections on their own experiences with race, class, gender, (dis)ability, and other identities in U.S. schools and society. The purpose of such reflections is two-fold: first, to emphasize everyone's stake in addressing the dilemmas raised in class discussions and assigned texts; and second, to identify blind spots and opportunities for growth for each of us in the course. Regardless of the insights gained from previous personal and professional experiences, all of us have the potential to deepen our awareness of how asymmetrical relations of power shape who we are and how we interact with others. This course will require students to introspectively explore how their social and cultural identities inform their engagements with schools and society, and to construct strategies that will facilitate such praxis (reflection and action) throughout their research, teaching, and counseling careers.

Land Acknowledgement

As a member of the Warner and Rochester Community, I would like to start this course by acknowledging the traditional territory of the Haudenosaunee and by honoring the sovereignty of the Six Nations–the Mohawk, Cayuga, Onondaga, Oneida, Seneca, and Tuscarora–and their land where we and the University of Rochester are situated. With this acknowledgment, we hope to demonstrate respect for the treaties that were made on these territories and remorse for the harms and mistakes of the past and those that continue today; and we pledge to work toward supporting greater public consciousness of Native sovereignty and cultural rights, a step toward equitable relationships and reconciliation. To learn more, please visit A Guide to Indigenous Land Acknowledgment.

Warner's Diversity and Inclusion Goals and Values

The Warner Graduate School of Education and Human Development is dedicated to fostering a learning community that represents and builds on the rich diversity of human experiences, backgrounds, cultures, histories, ideas, and ways of living. Consistent with our dedication to education, leadership, counseling, and human development that can transform lives and make the world more just and humane, we recruit, support, and learn with and from students, staff, and faculty from the broadest spectrum of human diversity. Likewise, we seek the same through our interactions with the broader local and global community (http://www.warner.rochester.edu/warnerataglance/diversity/)

Classroom Environment

This course is designed to facilitate students' examination of privilege and inequality and demands reflection and action, or what Freire[1] (1971) calls praxis, to do so. Class discussion may be difficult and challenging. We share, as a classroom community, the task of negotiating the dual priorities of authentic free speech and active regard for all others. Given the important work of leading social change, we need to have these discussions in a safe, supportive, anti-racist, and anti-oppressive environment where each person will be accountable for their language, actions, interactions, and ideologies when they may negatively impact others, whether intentional or unintentional. It is important that we share our insights, but it is also essential that we listen to each other, especially when someone addresses any incidents in class that feel hurtful. It is important that we listen to each other about how our words and actions are affecting one another and that we talk about a class moment in which something may feel hurtful. Free speech is welcome but hate speech (any slurs or attack on another's ideas and lived experiences) is not permitted. We will negotiate other guidelines about classroom discussions throughout the course.

Online Etiquette, Anti-Discrimination, and Sexual Harassment Policy

The University strictly prohibits the use of university online resources or facilities, including Blackboard, for the purpose of harassment of any individual or for the posting of any material that is scandalous, libelous, offensive, or otherwise against the University's policies. Please see: https://www.rochester.edu/policies/policy/discrimination-harassment/ and report an issue to the Office of Equity and Inclusion.

Title IX

All members of the University community have the right to learn and work in a safe environment free from all forms of harassment, including harassment on the basis of sex or gender. Students who have been subjected to sexual harassment, including sexual assault, dating/domestic violence, or stalking, have the right to receive academic, housing, transportation, or other accommodations, to receive counseling and health services and to make a report about such behavior to the University and to law enforcement. For more information, please visit http://www.rochester.edu/sexualmisconduct or contact Professor Carol St. George, Deputy Title IX Coordinator; cstgeorge@Warner.rochester.edu (585) 275-0967; LeChase Hall 454.

Accessibility and Accommodations

The University of Rochester respects and welcomes students of all backgrounds and abilities. In the event you encounter any barrier(s) to full participation in this course due to the impact of a disability, please contact the Office of Disability Resources. The access coordinators in the Office of Disability Resources can meet with you to discuss the barriers you are experiencing and explain the eligibility process for establishing academic accommodations. You can reach the Office of Disability Resources at: disability@rochester.edu; (585) 276-5075; Taylor Hall. You may also contact Mary Judge Diegert, Warner's Disability Resource Coordinator at mjudge@warner.rochester.edu (585) 273-1838; LeChase Hall 470.

Academic Integrity

Academic dishonesty is unacceptable and will not be tolerated. Cheating, forgery, plagiarism, and collusion in dishonest acts undermine the educational mission of the University of Rochester and the students' personal and intellectual growth. Please see the Regulations and University

[1] Freire, P. (1971). *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*. London, England, Penguin.

Policies Concerning Graduate Studies handbook:
https://www.rochester.edu/GradBulletin/PDFbulletin/Regulations.pdf

Religious Observances

If class meetings or assignments conflict with your religious observances, please contact me so that we can work out an alternative plan. Please let me know as soon as possible in the semester if you anticipate any conflicts.

UR Care Services

The CARE Network enables members of the University community to express their concern about a person, incident, or issue. If you are concerned about another student or yourself, please visit UR Care Network to make a referral: https://www.rochester.edu/care/.The University Counseling Center is also available for appointments and consultation for all U of R students (585) 275-3113.

Course Assignments

Class participation (15 points):
We need each other in this class, full stop. Coming to class having read the articles, watched or listened to the media, and prepared to have brave discussions about the sometimes-thorny issues we will be grappling with is paramount to your success and to our collective success. You are not expected to come to any stances or conclusions– grappling with ideas and issues is the key task.

Discussion of readings and other resources (10 points): You are assigned to two groups (see below). When it is your group's turn to do so, students will facilitate our discussion of readings by each posting 2 questions each that emerged from the set of assigned readings by noon on the day of class. We will use your questions to drive discussion during class. Additionally, you will be in charge of facilitating the discussion. You can use slides or paper activities, but the general goal is to get everyone involved and engaged with the readings (Less of the professor just talking at you). Please take this task seriously, as it will work in place of traditional discussion posts on Blackboard that I have found to be less productive. Examples of good posing questions are here: Productive questions

Group A posts by noon before class: Class 3, 6, 8, and 11
Group B posts by noon before class: Class 4, 7, 9, and 12

Group A: TBD

Group B: TBD

Beyond attendance, participating in class discussions, and completing readings, you are expected to view films and social media content as part of developing anti-oppressive practice. We will watch the documentary film 13th, write reflective notes, and discuss what we learned from the film in class. Additionally, there are excellent social media influencers dedicated to anti-oppressive work that we will investigate together. I have put together a brief list of TikTok content creators as a start. Use your algorithm from there to guide you where you feel is

important. You may have other social media accounts that deserve our attention.

- *Thirteenth* Movie Viewing and Notes
    - Prior to Class on Monday, March 16, students are asked to view the film *Thirteenth* and engage in an interactive, class note-catcher - both available on Blackboard. *Thirteenth* is a 2016 American documentary film by director Ava DuVernay. The film explores the "intersection of race, justice, and mass incarceration in the United States;" it is titled after the Thirteenth Amendment to the United States Constitution, adopted in 1865, which abolished slavery throughout the United States and ended involuntary servitude except as a punishment for conviction of a crime. Please be aware that this movie has graphic content and information about state-sanctioned violence against Black and Brown individuals and bodies. This graphic content exists throughout the film. Take the time you need while watching this film - we need to bear witness to this violence. However, it is not easy.
- In-Class Participation
- Engagement in Class Readings
- Social media viewing and commentary

Self-portrait and Artist Statement (Due February 16): (25 points)

Each student will create a self-portrait that represents how they define themselves in relation to race, class, gender, (dis)ability, and other salient identity categories. These self-portraits should creatively reflect the communities and groups with whom students identify and reflect the cultural influences that have helped shape who they are as a person. Self-portraits can be created digitally or manually, with a copy of either format uploaded to Blackboard. We will share these representations with each other as a group.

In addition to the self-portrait that you will share with classmates, you must also write an Artist's Statement of 250 words or less describing your portrait, your reasoning behind your portrait decisions, and information about the artist (you).

Resources for writing an Artist's Statement:

- *The Creative Independent: How to Write an Artist Statement*
- *The Complete Guide to Writing an Artist Statement in 2021*

Guiding questions for discussing these representations are:

- In what ways does society support/not support who you are as a cultural being?
- What did this project ask you to confront that you found challenging?
- What structures and/or systems of power are linked with the realities you represented regarding your identity?
- Why did you choose the identities that are represented in your self-portrait? What makes these identities significant enough for you to include them in this self-portrait?
- What categories did you steer away from in this self-portrait, and why? Or what aspects of the identities in your self-portrait did you not represent, and why?
- Which of your identities do you feel comfortable bringing into your educational settings as an educator and which do you not feel comfortable bringing into educational

settings?

Deconstructing Bias (Due April 13): (25 points)

This project requires students to examine the prejudices, biases, and stereotypes they hold about a particular community or group. After determining where personal biases, prejudices, or stereotypes may lie, students will observe activity of this group or community in an online or in-person setting and write a personal reflection paper, critically examining their experience. Papers should be 5-7 pages and include citations from our class readings or digital sources.

Questions to consider:

- How will you thoughtfully connect with this group?
  - What do you need to consider for your own safety and well-being?
- What current myths/assumptions exist about this group?
  - What does it mean to you to engage with this group when you have such assumptions?
  - What does it mean to engage with this group in your current or future work setting (classroom, clinic, etc.)?
- What assets (funds of knowledge) did you observe?
  - What can you learn from this group?
- What did you learn from this observation and reflection that will inform your future work?

Impacting practice (May 4): (35% of grade)

A key goal of EDU442 is to help you apply a critical awareness of the social contexts of education to your roles as educators and educational advocates. To that end, this assignment asks you to design an impacting practice project that provides tangible strategies for addressing a dilemma related to race, class, gender, (dis)ability, or another marker of social difference in American K-12 (or post-secondary) education. Since the goal of this assignment is for you to develop something that can be of use to you in your practice as a reform-minded educator or educational advocate, you have a fair amount of leeway in terms of what you can pursue.

Students will consider materials from the course thus far and their own experience(s) in school settings to develop a tool for effecting justice and equity-oriented change. This tool can focus on a range of topics or concept areas based on student choice, as well as executed in various formats (e.g., curriculum units, professional development modules, policy briefs, student leadership trainings, etc.). I am open to additional ideas of interpretations and presentation if a rationale for how it meets course goals is provided and pre-approved. Students will share their project in round table format during our last class on April 28th (Final version of project due May 4th). Please provide any materials you developed as part of your presentation.

Possible project ideas include:

1. Lesson Plan: *Provides a framework for teaching specific learning content, often a part of a larger unit, that is focused on related topics, outcomes, or goals. Lesson plans are guided by state learning standards and developed for particular age ranges and content areas.*

2. Professional Development: *Provides opportunities for professionals (teachers, counselors, administrators, etc.) to increase their engagement with specific populations (students, parents, teachers, clients, patients, etc.) and develop practices associated with their field (Ex. Pedagogical Practices, Online Seminars, Skill-Building Opportunities).*
3. Leadership Appeal: *Is a thoughtful and critical argument for or request to those in a leadership position (Law/Policy-Makers, Superintendents, Principles, etc.), advocating for adjusted resources, opportunities, decisions, or laws that directly impact students, clients, and or patients in various fields.*

IMPORTANT TO KNOW:

The writing standard for this course is American Psychological Association (APA) formatting. All written individual and group papers should follow this standard. Informal discussions online do not have to adhere strictly to APA formatting however, for consistency it is recommended that all references included in these types of discussions meet the APA guidelines. Adhering to APA formatting in these assignments will get you used to using it as the default in your scholarly discourse. For additional assistance, please consider purchasing the Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association, Sixth Edition. See the Purdue Writing Lab for handy resources: https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/research_and_citation/apa_style/apa_formatting_and_style_guide/general_format.html

Late Work and Extensions

In principle, late work will not be accepted. Deadlines are assigned to support you in your progression, as well as to ensure that I can provide thoughtful feedback. Trying to stay on track with these due dates will ultimately support the development of knowledge in this course for the entire community. As things will come up, we each need grace as we learn, survive, and thrive. If an assignment extension is needed, please contact me at least two days prior to the assignment due date. Together, we will decide on an appropriate extended due date.

Required Text:

Talusan, L. (2022). *The identity-conscious educator: Building Habits & Skills for a more inclusive school*. Solution Tree Press.

Available online through River Campus Library

Additional readings are posted on Blackboard.

Grading

Deconstructing Bias:	25 points
Self Portrait:	15 points
Impacting Practice:	35 points
Discussant question:	10 points
Class participation:	15 points
Total:	100 points

10		15		25		35		100	
10 – 8	A	15 – 13	A	25 – 23	A	35 – 33	A	100 – 96	A
7 – 5	B	12 – 10	A-	22 – 20	A-	32 – 30	A-	95 – 91	A-

<4	C	9 – 8	B+	19 – 17	B+	29 – 27	B+	90 – 86	B+
		7 – 6	B	16 – 15	B	26 – 25	B	85 – 81	B
		<5	C	<14	C	<24	C	80 – 76	B-
								<75	C

Class Schedule (ALL READINGS HYPERLINKED) (Also available in class google drive)

[1] January 26 *Overview of the course* **Introduction, pgs. 1-14** of Bell, D. (2018). *Faces at the bottom of the well : the permanence of racism*. Basic Books.
[2] February 2 *Beginning the journey* Readings: hooks, b. (1994). Chapter 3: Embracing Change: Teaching in a Multicultural World. *Teaching to transgress,* pp. 35-44. Routledge. Talusan, L. (2022). *The identity-conscious educator: Building Habits & Skills for a more inclusive school*. Introduction & Part 1. Solution Tree Press.
[3] February 9: **Group A posts** *Intersectionalities* Readings: Leo, A. (2023). Toward a class-conscious approach to cultural responsiveness. *Educational Researcher, 52*(4), 230-237. Schalk, S., & Kim, J. B. (2020). Integrating race, transforming feminist disability studies. *Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society, 46*(1), 31-55. Watch: The Urgency of Intersectionality. TedTalk by Kimberle Crenshaw
[4] February 16 **Group B posts** *Critically raced* **Self-Portrait and Artist's Statement Due** Readings: Coles, J. A. (2023). A BlackCrit re/imagining of urban schooling social education through black youth enactments of Black storywork. *Urban Education (Beverly Hills, Calif.)*, *58*(6), 1180–1209. Ladson-Billings, G. & Tate, W. (1995). Toward a critical race theory of education. *Teachers College Record*, *97*(1), 47 – 68. Pizarro, M., & Kohli, R. (2020). "I Stopped Sleeping": Teachers of Color and the Impact of Racial Battle Fatigue. *Urban Education (Beverly Hills, Calif.)*, *55*(7), 967–991.
[5] February 23 *Rethinking Pedagogies* Readings: Blackburn, M. V. (2021). Pedagogy and pleasure: Trans and gender transgressive students in an LGBTQ-themed literature class. *Pedagogy, Culture & Society*, *29*(5), 773-791. Paris, D. & Alim, H. (2014). What are we seeking to sustain through culturally sustaining pedagogy? A loving critique forward. *Harvard Educational Review*, 84(1), 85-100.
[6] March 2 **Group A posts** *Intersectionality, identity, and decolonization* Readings:

Gill, V. (2022). Intersectional (ity) pedagogy: Conceptualizing soul work toward solidarity and resistance. *The Educational Forum* (86)4, 382-395.

Werito, V. (2025). "What You Know You Hold Onto It ... that is Being Navajo": A Critical Analysis of Diné (Indigenous) Youth's Perspectives about Race, Culture, Language, and Identity. *Journal of Language, Identity, and Education*, *24*(1), 14–27.

[7] March 9 **Group B posts**

Linguistic diversity

Readings:

Austin, T., & Anya, U. (2024). World languages for Black Linguistic Reparations. *Foreign Language Annals*, *57*(2), 288–310.

Baker-Bell, A. (2020). Dismantling anti-black linguistic racism in English language arts classrooms: Toward an anti-racist black language pedagogy. *Theory into Practice*, *59*(1), 8–21.

Recommended/Optional:

Smitherman, G. (1999). Introduction to ebonics. In *talkin that talk: Language, culture, and education in African America*, pp. 19 – 40. Routledge.

[8] March 16 **Group A posts**

School to prison pipeline

13th Note catcher due

Readings:

James-Gallaway, C. D. (2022). "The kids in prison program": a critical race personal counternarrative of a former Black charter school teacher. *Teachers College Record (1970)*, *124*(11), 58–81.

Marsh, V. (2017, October). *Becoming restorative: Three schools transitioning to a restorative practices culture*.

Stevenson, B. (2021). Punishment. In N. Hannah-Jones, *The 1619 Project*, pp. 431-456. Random House. **Access to E-Book through UR library

[9] March 23 **Group B posts**

Class, schooling, and precarious knowing

Readings:

Desmond, M. (2021). Capitalism. In N. Hannah-Jones, *The 1619 Project*, pp. 259-306. Random House. **Access to E-Book through UR library

Fine, M., Greene, C., & Sanchez, S. (2016). Neoliberal blues and prec(ar)ious knowledge. *Urban Review*, 48, 499-519.

Talusan, L. (2022). *The identity-conscious educator: Building Habits & Skills for a more inclusive school*. Ch. 4 (Class). Solution Tree Press.

[10] March 30

Gender, Gender Identity, and Sexuality
Readings:
Blair, E. & Deckman, S. (2022). Beyond pronouns: The case for gender-expansive and democratizing practice in teacher education. *Teachers College Record, 124*(8), 275-286. https://doi.org/10.1177/01614681221124194
Rende Mendoza, K. & Johnson, C. (2024). A (TRANS)formative approach to gender-inclusive science education, *Journal of Research in Science Teaching, 61*, 937-971.
Talusan, L. (2022). *The identity-conscious educator: Building Habits & Skills for a more inclusive school*. pp. Ch. 6 Gender. Solution Tree Press.

[11] April 6 **Group A posts**
The "F" Word
Readings:
Bianca, H. (2020). Extending bell hooks' feminist theory, *Journal of International Women's Studies, 21*(1), 13-29.
Grande, S. (2003). Whitestream feminism and the colonialist project: A review of contemporary feminist pedagogy and praxis. *Educational Theory, 53*(3), 329 – 346.
Roberts, K. M. (2021). Integrating feminist theory, pedagogy, and praxis into teacher education. *SAGE Open*, *11*(3), 21582440211023120.

NOTE: Use Part III in Talusan to support your Impacting Practice assignment

[12] April 13 **Group B posts**
Inclusion and constructing others
Readings:
Annanema, S., Connor, D., Ferri, B. (2013). Dis/ability critical race studies (DisCrit): Theorizing at the intersections of race and dis/ability. Race Ethnicity and Education, 16(1), 1-31.
Flynn, S. (2024). Critical disability studies and the affirmative non-tragedy model: presenting a theoretical frame for disability and child protection, *Disability & Society, 39*(2), 269-290. DOI: 10.1080/09687599.2022.2070061
Talusan, L. (2022). *The identity-conscious educator: Building Habits & Skills for a more inclusive school*. Ch. 7 Disability. Solution Tree Press.

[13] April 20
Joy and Refusal
Impacting Practice presentations and project due
Readings:
Edwards, E. B., & Reynolds, A. D. (2025). You Can't Steal My Joy! Practices and Possibilities for Black Joy in Urban Education. *Urban Education (Beverly Hills, Calif.)*, *60*(11), 2907–2927.
Okello, W. K. (2025). Unspeakable Joy: Anti-Black Constraint, Loopholes of Retreat, and the Practice of Black Joy. *Urban Education (Beverly Hills, Calif.)*, *60*(11), 2928–2955.

Vlach, S. K., Lentz, T. S., & Muhammad, G. E. (2023). Activating Joy Through Culturally and Historically Responsive Read-Alouds. *The Reading Teacher*, *77*(1), 121–130.
[14] April 27 **STEPHANIE TOLIVER LIBERATORY FUTURES** *Liberatory Goals/Reimagining Futures* **Impacting practice roundtable** Readings: Toliver, S. R. (2022). Dreamland: Black Girls Saying and Creating Space through Fantasy Worlds. *Girlhood Studies*, *15*(1), 17–33. Naraian, S. (2021) Making inclusion matter: critical disability studies and teacher education, *Journal of Curriculum Studies, 53*(3), 298-313. DOI: 10.1080/00220272.2021.1882579
[15] May 5 (NO class Impacting Practice project due)